DELIVER LIVING DOCUMENTATION

The reports produced by executable specifications aren't simply technical reports for developers but effectively become a form of product documentation for the whole team, expressed in a vocabulary familiar to users (see figure 1.11). This documentation is always up to date and requires little or no manual maintenance. It's automatically produced from the latest version of the application. Each application feature is described in readable terms and is illustrated by a few key examples. For web applications, this sort of living documentation often also includes screenshots of the application for each feature.

Experienced teams organize this documentation so that it's easy to read and easy for everyone involved in the project to use (see figure 1.12). Developers can consult it to see how existing features work. Testers and business analysts can see how the features they specified have been implemented. Product owners and project managers can use summary views to judge the current state of the project, view progress, and decide what features can be released into production. Users can even use it to see what the application can do and how it works.

Just as automated acceptance criteria provide great documentation for the whole team, low-level executable specifications also provide excellent technical documentation for other developers. This documentation is always up to date, is cheap to maintain, contains working code samples, and expresses the intent behind each specification.

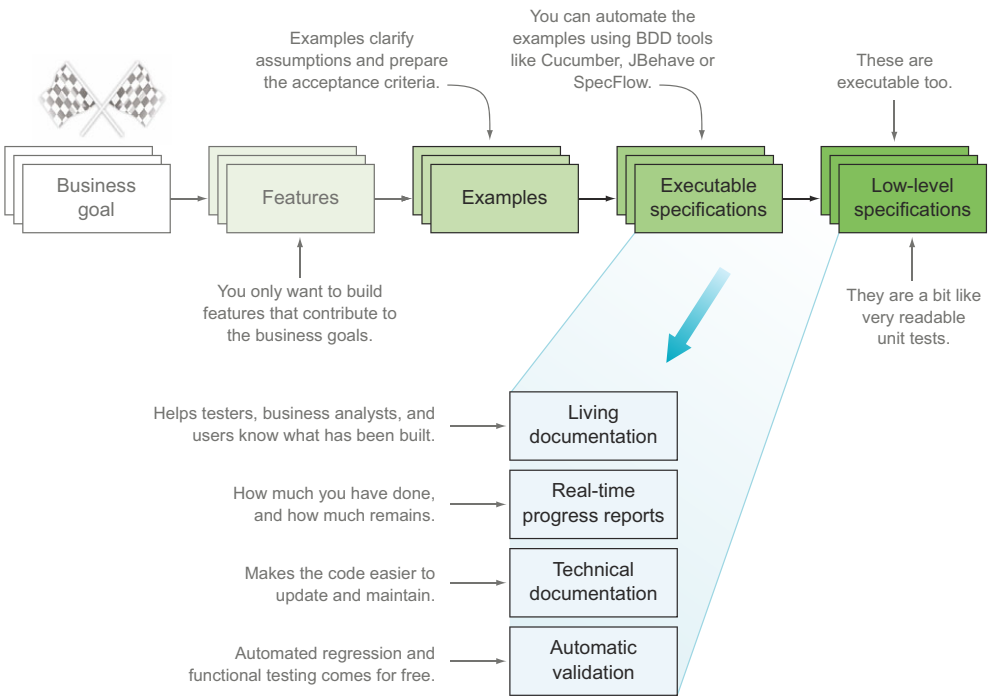


Figure 1.11 High-level and low-level executable specifications generate different sorts of living documentation for the system.